has been reduced to a Hindu-Muslim binary. The ruling dispensation believes they will perpetuate themselves in power by othering the other continually and keep religious polarisation on a continuous burn. This myopic politics will tear this country asunder. It is a myth that the Congress sides with one community to the detriment of the other. However, we will delude ourselves if we deny that our opponents have succeeded in creating this perception. The Congress must remain true to its idea of India, namely that every Indian irrespective of faith, caste, region and any disability is an equal stakeholder in the Indian Republic.

Q. Why has the Congress failed to strengthen its grassroots organisational structure so that it can take its message to the ground?
The Congress has office-bearers but that does not make the sum total of the essence of a political organisation. An organisation is something more than a couple of eminences at various levels, having an adjective attached to their noun.

Q. Do you think the Congress has failed to project a leader to counter the popularity of Prime Minister Narendra Modi?
Leadership for 2024 is a key question. It is the 600-pound omnipresent but invisible gorilla in the room. That is the biggest conundrum for the Opposition, severally and jointly. The presidential elections in July 2022 provide the Opposition with a platform to field a joint candidate who could probably then be the prime ministerial candidate in 2024. The pre-requisite is that the Opposition zero in on a senior political figure who is then acceptable to everyone. After all, Narendra Modi

" A fair, transparent, and credible electoral process needs to play itself out. Those who can fight the BJP juggernaut 24X7 need to come forward "

emerged as a prime minister challenger in May 2013 in Goa. If the Opposition fails to agree on a joint candidate in the presidential polls, it still has one year to get its act together.

Q. Is the Congress alienating regional parties because of the ambitions of their leaders or due to its own leadership's arrogance?
Opposition leaders must answer a fundamental question—what are they fighting for? To save the constitutional idea of India or the loaves and fishes of office? Once they find an answer to that, the rest should fall into place. Of course, the Congress must be prepared to demonstrate flexibility and magnanimity on the leadership issue.

Q. Several young Congress leaders have quit in the past two years.
It is a combination of two factors. The first is ideological dilution. Since the glue of a clear philosophical underpinning came unstuck over the years, the Congress became an instrument to put some people into public office. When younger elements, who had very tenuous or non-existent ideological commitment except to the idea of power, realised their ambitions could not be fulfilled in the short term, they hitched their horses to different wagons. The second is the collapse of hope. When hope is lost, desperation sets in and an 'every person for himself' syndrome takes root. That is what convulsed younger elements who left the Congress. They never had the stomach for the long haul. Would it be fair to make a value judgement on their choices? I do not know, given how things have panned out. ■

to Kishor's formula for revival—that the Congress focus on the nearly 200 (out of 543) seats where it is in direct contest with the BJP and play second fiddle in states where a non-BJP party may be stronger as in West Bengal or in Telangana. This could help consolidate the non-BJP votes and eventually enable the Opposition parties to trounce the saffron challenge. It's something even a Trinamool Congress leader advocates, though as a word of caution. "Please focus on winning in states where you are alone against the BJP. Leave the states where regional parties are strong. You will still have more seats than any regional party. If this principle is adhered to, there will be no need for any grand alliance of Opposition parties to beat the BJP."

But the opposite seems to be happening. The Congress fought against the Samajwadi Party and the TMC in UP and West Bengal, respectively, this year. In Goa, it had to jostle with the TMC and the Aam Aadmi Party to occupy the anti-BJP space. In Telangana, the Congress will challenge the KCR's Telangana Rashtra Samithi. While regional parties blame the Congress's arrogance for preventing the formation of any alliance, the party, in turn, dismisses them as representing the "exaggerated ambitions" of regional leaders.

It is this very arrogance that the Congress will have to shed if it wants to survive. It also has to get realistic and get its house in order without wasting even a moment. It has to find the right message, the right messenger to deliver it and mobilise an army of foot-soldiers that can act as force multipliers. For the grand old party, it is truly now or never. ■